

Shoot at Sight

Must-have games that will create a storm

MEDAL OF HONOR: ALLIED ASSAULT

Saving Private Powell

Allied Assault is the first game in the *Medal of Honor (MOH)* series to reach the PC—it has its roots in the PlayStation. Originally conceived by Dreamworks Interactive (the game development unit of Spielberg's movie production company), it won the Best of Show award at E3, 2001.

The game is obviously inspired by the award-winning film, *Saving Private Ryan*, and includes several identical settings, including a replication of the Omaha Beach invasion. Thanks to the polygon-crunching powers of today's cards, *Medal of Honor* comes pretty close to capturing the same intensity of war. Set in the war years between 1942 and 1945 in the European arena, you don the role of an elite army ranger, Lieutenant Mike Powell, a versatile soldier involved in every historic Allied offensive during that period. You can spy, snipe, drive a tank, and you are as effective at infiltrating and

spying as you are on the front lines of the D-Day invasion. You'll see action against the Africa Corps, sabotage U-Boats, storm Omaha Beach on D-Day, and infiltrate Nazi strongholds and labs to tackle their deadly technological advances.

Even shooter novices should feel at home in no time. The controls let the game shine through. One of the finest innovations of *MOH* is the compass, displayed at the upper left corner of the screen. A small arrow continually points you towards your next objective, and virtually guarantees that you'll never find yourself lost during a mission. This does not mean that the gameplay is always run and gun. Some missions require you to use radio and binoculars, while others require you to find specialty items such as gas masks or ID papers to continue.

EA has found the ideal middle ground between realism and fun. The range of

effects rivals Spielberg's Oscar winning film. Facial expressions, immersive gameplay, authentic World War II guns—this game leads in almost all departments.

The game uses a modified version of the *Quake III* graphics engine, with good results. It's not as breathtakingly beautiful as *Return to Castle Wolfenstein*, but is as close to reality as it can get. Character models are equally well done, with excellent facial detail.

If you have a strong enough rig to crank up the effects, the results are quite spectacular. It does take a monster of a PC to run the game smoothly at high-detail levels, but those with the horsepower to run *Max Payne* and *Return to Castle Wolfenstein* should be covered.

If you're just looking for the best single player experience, a game that makes your jaw drop, feeds your itchy trigger finger, and makes your GeForce3 come to life, then *MOH: Allied Assault* is for you.

Genre: FPS/Action

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